

Westhampton, MA Finance Committee Meeting Minutes

Westhampton Town Hall

March 11, 2026

Meeting Called to order at 7:05 pm

In attendance were FinCom Board members: Tad Weiss, Jeremy Durrin, Maureen Dempsey, Jon Albitz (Notetaker), Steve Holt, Jennifer Milikowsky (Remote)

Also in attendance was Douglas Finn, Bill and Janice Tracy, Chief of Police (David White), Fire Chief (David Antosz) and Highway Superintendent (William Jablonski),

Motion to approve meeting minutes from previous meeting by Jeremy Durrin, seconded by Jon Albitz.

VOTE: Approved: 6-0-0

Discussed Reserve Funds transfer to Counsel Fees. \$9000 for the rest of the fiscal year. Tad made the motion to transfer funds and Maureen seconded.

VOTE: Approved: 6-0-0

Weiss meeting with Milikowsky and Durrin on Monday to finalize presentation.

March 24th Tuesday night FinCom meeting at Elementary school. March 25th Public Informational meeting on Proposition 2-1/2 Override at town hall.

Chief White said none of the town heads knew about tonight's meeting.

Weiss said there was an updated deficit of another \$34k identified. He did not want to use \$34K free cash to balance the budget. He asked if there were places in Public Safety and Highways to make these cuts.

Finn said we could save \$19k by not doing an audit this year.

March 19th regional school meeting. We should get finalized budget numbers.

Chief Antosz said his budget came in at minus 18%, doesn't think he can cut anything else. Utility reserve of \$2000 and misc./repair of \$2500 can be eliminated but it could add risk if problems arise. A/C system and sprinkler system need service. Some trucks need new tires etc. It was pointed out that much of the cuts Antosz recommended came as a result of solar panels eliminating utility charges.

Regarding highways, Jablonski said the town needs to know these reductions are cutting out the backbone of the town.

Weiss stated over the last 4 years the school increases to Westhampton have averaged between 2% and 3%. Covid money may have hidden growing financial challenges at schools, which appear to be financially struggling.

Highway department lost an employee, Austin Norris, because of a better offer, and uncertainty if his position would be cut. Town austerity adds uncertainty to the livelihoods of town employees and keeping good people will be harder.

Chief White said he wanted to hire another part-time employee (previously approved by SB for the current year) but decided against – due to future uncertainty of funding for the position. He will also have to drop hours from 60 down to 50 if override doesn't pass. 252 calls this year in the first 70 days. He thinks this number is up and will get Weiss numbers.

Chief Antosz asked us not to mess with the Easthampton Ambulance Service contract [despite it going up in cost]. He felt it an amazing value to the town.

Jablonski said the town would have to cut transfer station hours down to Saturday-only, which reduces payroll \$12k per year. Roads will suffer. We may lose chapter 90 [State Highway grants] money if we can't keep up certain standards due to budget cuts. The town had a study done that assessed the roads using state and national standards. We are at 84%. They said the budget for highway maintenance should be \$600k per year to just maintain our roads.

Bill Tracy thinks we should use stabilization and free cash to balance the budget and only do a \$100k Prop 2-1/2 Override. Weiss rebutted with several reasons why using savings would not be a good idea including: already low savings available, using savings would not help solve the structural deficit for future years, funds would not be available for capital needs in the future, and our town bond rating might suffer when we next need to borrow money.

Chief White said we should let people know there is a worse-case scenario than even the austerity budget if school budgets come in higher than projected. [The current town budget assumes final school budgets will land close to where they are today. Should *final* school budgets increase, the deficit will be worse, and new austerity savings will be necessary]

Chief White said department heads have turned back money year-over-year instead of spending it all and that is [partially] where our Stabilization Fund and Free Cash has come from. This should be known by all the town's people.

We reviewed slides for the upcoming informational meetings

Weiss asked the three department heads what they were most concerned about with the 12.5% Austerity Budget [the budget we may have to propose at TM should the Override fail]:

- Chief White: most concerned about not being able to offer enough services.

- Chief Antosz: is most concerned about mandatory spending, turn-out gear (protective ensemble for fire suppression and keeping the firefighters as safe as possible), tires, NFPA and OSHA training and manuals.
- Superintendent Jablonski is most concerned about road maintenance, equipment maintenance, and unforeseen costs. CDL licensing is \$5k if we need to do training for the new hire.

Budget for fuel has always been at \$5/Gallon and has always created a buffer for us. Now diesel is actually \$5/Gallon. Propane is bound to increase as well. Discussion on whether we need to increase fuel budget due to rapidly rising fuel costs. Further discussion on whether to increase Reserve Fund to cover unanticipated cost rises like this.

Motion to adjourn by Albitz at 9:05pm, seconded by Milikowsky.

VOTE: Approved: 6-0-0